

Customer Issue Escalation Procedure

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Owner: Customer Retention Operations

1. Purpose

This procedure defines how customer issues are classified by severity and escalated between the front-line support team, the retention team, and management. Its goal is to resolve issues before they become cancellation triggers.

2. Severity Classification

Severity	Definition	First Response	Resolution Target
Severity 1	Total service outage, safety issue, or regulatory compliance	15 minutes	4 hours
Severity 2	Partial outage, repeated billing error, or explicit cancellation threat	1 hour	1 business day
Severity 3	Degraded service quality, single billing dispute	4 hours	3 business days
Severity 4	General inquiry, feature request, feedback	1 business day	5 business days

3. Escalation Path

Level 1 — Front-line agent: owns Severity 3 and 4 issues end to end. Level 2 — Retention specialist: automatically receives any interaction containing an explicit cancellation threat, any Severity 2 issue open for more than 8 business hours, and any customer flagged 'high churn risk' in the CRM. Level 3 — Team supervisor: receives Severity 1 issues immediately, and any issue where the customer requests a manager or where the proposed remedy exceeds agent authority under the Retention Discount Policy (RET-POL-021). Level 4 — Retention Operations Manager: receives unresolved Severity 1 issues after 4 hours and approves all exception-level remedies.

4. Cancellation Threats

Any statement such as 'I want to cancel', 'I am switching providers', or 'close my account' must be classified at minimum Severity 2 and transferred warm (agent stays on the line during handover) to a retention specialist within 10 minutes. If no specialist is available, the agent schedules a callback within 4 business hours and flags the account RETAIN-PENDING. Cold transfers of cancellation threats are a reportable process violation.

5. Documentation Requirements

Every escalation must include: the severity level, a two-sentence issue summary, actions already taken, the customer's stated desired outcome, and the account's churn-risk score if available. Escalations missing any of these fields may be returned to the originating agent, and the resolution clock is not paused by a return.

6. De-escalation Guidance

Retention specialists should first resolve the underlying issue before discussing offers. Data from Q4 2025 shows that resolving the root cause first improves save rate by roughly 20 points compared with leading with a discount. Discounts are governed exclusively by RET-POL-021 and must never be improvised.